

for. He did not fully understand interest rates. And he didn't know that you can't consolidate your loans if your debt has been sold.

That's right! Student loans, if they're private, can be sold to debt collection agencies and banks you never took loans from. John said some of his loans have been sold off so many times that he'll just get a random letter in the mail from a bank he's never heard of saying, "Hey, you owe us \$9,000."

"I'll try to contact them and be like, 'Well, what is this debt in reference to?' They can't tell you. They don't know," he said.

On his illuminating late-night show *Last Week Tonight*, John Oliver elaborates on this phenomenon. In a segment called "Debt Buyers," Oliver explains that delinquent debts (over ninety days late) have given birth to a whole industry of outside companies buying debt from banks and other lenders, creating a debt maze. Banks are selling off debt to create more money for more loans, and then these debt-buying companies can come after *you* because you now owe *them* money. So you may have taken out a loan with Bank of America, but by the time you pay it back, you have no idea who you're paying, which is what's happening to our buddy John Brunson.

The information being sold isn't always truthful. It can get shuffled around or lost or change hands many times, and the debt buyers don't check if they have it right before they come to collect. (And if you're not on top of it? You could pay a loan off TWICE.)

"Some [debt collectors] work within the boundaries of the law," John Oliver warned on his show. But others will call your house, your family members, your employer, leave threatening voicemails, or tell consumers that if they can't pay they should kill themselves. Debt buyers also disproportionately come after people in black or Latino neighborhoods, according to the Human Rights Watch. Oliver reported that the debt buyers can legally sue people (which they do a lot). When 95 percent don't show up for their court dates, the debt buyer wins by default and can garnish the indebted person's wages—again, all legally. None of this has happened to John Brunson yet, but he expects it is coming in his future. "It's all a tangled confused web now," he said.

He knows he should pay the loans off, but all told, if he paid the amount he needed to every month to be able to pay it off in a timely fashion, it'd be more